

## Definitions and Examples of 15 Cognitive Distortions

| # | Cognitive Distortion                                         | Definition                                                                                         | Example                                                                                                   |
|---|--------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1 | <b>Dichotomous thinking</b> (all-or-nothing/black and white) | Viewing situations, people, or events in extreme, all-or-nothing terms rather than on a continuum. | "I made a mistake, therefore I'm a failure".                                                              |
| 2 | <b>Fortune telling</b> (catastrophizing)                     | Predicting the future in negative terms and believing the outcome will be unbearable.              | "I will fail, and this will be unbearable".                                                               |
| 3 | <b>Discounting or disqualifying the positive</b>             | Insisting that positive experiences or events do not count.                                        | "I passed the exam, but I was just lucky".                                                                |
| 4 | <b>Emotional reasoning</b>                                   | Believing that emotions reflect reality and letting them guide judgments.                          | "I am terrified of airplanes, so flying must be dangerous".                                               |
| 5 | <b>Labeling</b>                                              | Putting a fixed, global, usually negative label on oneself or others.                              | "I'm a loser" or "He's a rotten person".                                                                  |
| 6 | <b>Magnification/minimization</b>                            | Magnifying negatives and/or minimizing positives when evaluating oneself or others.                | "I got a B. This proves how inferior I am".                                                               |
| 7 | <b>Selective abstraction</b> (mental filter/tunnel vision)   | Paying attention to one or a few details while failing to see the whole picture.                   | "Even though the group said my work was good, one person pointed out an error so I know I will be fired". |
| 8 | <b>Mind reading</b>                                          | Believing one knows the thoughts or intentions of others without sufficient evidence.              | "He's thinking that I failed".                                                                            |

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|----|------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 9  | <b>Overgeneralization</b>                            | Taking isolated cases and generalizing them widely using words like "always" or "never".                                | "Every time I have a day off from work, it rains".                     |
| 10 | <b>Personalizing</b>                                 | Assuming the behaviors of others or external events concern oneself without considering other explanations.             | "I felt disrespected because the cashier did not say thank you to me". |
| 11 | <b>Should statements</b><br>(musts/oughts/have to's) | Telling oneself that events or behaviors "should" be the way they were expected rather than how they really are.        | "I should have been a better mother".                                  |
| 12 | <b>Jumping to conclusions</b>                        | Drawing conclusions from little or no confirmatory evidence.                                                            | "As soon as I saw him, I knew he had bad intentions".                  |
| 13 | <b>Blaming</b>                                       | Directing attention to others as the source of negative feelings, or taking responsibility for the behaviors of others. | "My parents are the ones to blame for my unhappiness".                 |
| 14 | <b>What if?</b>                                      | Constantly asking questions about potential negative events happening.                                                  | "What if my car crashes?".                                             |
| 15 | <b>Unfair comparisons</b>                            | Comparing oneself with others who seem to do better and placing oneself in a disadvantageous position.                  | "I am a failure because she is more successful than I am".             |